How an Order Works: The Complete Lifecycle

A simple, step-by-step walk-through of how orders move through V FOODS from start to finish.

1. Student Wallet Top-Up (via PhonePe)

- Students add money to their prepaid balance inside the Wallet tab.
- Payment is handled exclusively by **PhonePe**, supporting all UPI apps (PhonePe, Google Pay, BHIM) and bank cards.
- **Fee Rules**:
- **UPI / RuPay**: 0% fee. If a student adds ₹100, they pay ₹100 and receive exactly ₹100 in their wallet.
- **Credit / Debit Cards**: A small bank processing fee is calculated using the reverse formula (`Amount / 0.9765`) so the student still receives the full clean amount in their wallet.
- Once PhonePe completes the transaction, it sends an automatic instant notification called a **webhook** to our server.
- Our server verifies the digital signature to ensure the notification is genuine, then credits the student's wallet balance.
- **Safety Guarantee**: Every payment uses an unchangeable transaction key. Even if the network sends the confirmation twice by mistake, the database guarantees the wallet is only credited once.
- **Key Rule**: PhonePe is used ONLY for wallet top-ups. Food orders are never routed through PhonePe directly.

2. Menu Browsing & Cart Assembly

- Students browse campus canteens (such as Gazebo, Dakshin Chitra, and North Square) or festival stalls.
- Every canteen shows its live status (Open or Closed), wait times, customer ratings, and cuisine tags.
- Dishes clearly display vegetarian or non-vegetarian badges, current stock levels, and bestseller tags.
- Students can customize their order with extra options:
- **Coupons**: Apply discount promo codes to save money.
- **Scheduled Pickup**: Pick a specific future 15-minute pickup slot to beat the peak lunch rush.
- **Group Ordering**: Share a code so friends can combine items into one order.

3. Checkout: Dual Payment Options (Wallet or Instant Gateway)

When ready to order, the student chooses their preferred payment method:

- **Method A: Campus Prepaid Wallet**:
- Deducts the meal total from the student's prepaid balance in under one second.
- Zero bank loading spinners, zero OTPs, zero network delay.
- If the wallet balance is low, the student can 1-tap top up the deficit or switch to Instant Gateway.
- **Method B: Instant Payment Gateway (PhonePe / Paytm UPI)**:
- Connects directly to PhonePe, Paytm, Google Pay, or any UPI app.
- Allows immediate payment per order without needing prior wallet balance.
- Once authorized by the bank, the order is confirmed and sent directly to the kitchen.

Regardless of payment method: - The database confirms the canteen is open and stock is reserved. - A unique 4-digit pickup token number (such as `284`) and secure pickup QR pass are generated instantly.

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4. Kitchen Queue Dispatch via Realtime

- The moment the database records the order, Supabase sends a live WebSocket signal directly to the canteen's kitchen screen.
- A notification chime rings on the counter tablet.
- The order instantly pops up in the **Incoming / Placed** column with its token number, item quantities, and special cooking notes.
- Kitchen staff never need to refresh their browser or check paper printouts.

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5. Automatic & Manual Stock Tracking

- **Automatic Deduction**: The database automatically decreases available stock by the quantities ordered. If a dish reaches zero portions remaining, it automatically flips to "Sold Out" so nobody else can order it.
- **Staff Controls**: Kitchen cooks can also adjust stock manually using quick buttons (+1, -1, +5, -5) or tap the one-click **86** button to immediately mark an item sold out if fresh ingredients run out.

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6. Food Preparation & Milestone Progression

- Kitchen staff update the order step-by-step on their screen:
- **Placed**: Order received and queued.
- **Preparing**: Cook starts preparing the food. The student's screen updates in real time to show their food is cooking.
- **Ready**: Food is packaged and placed on the pickup counter.

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7. Ready-for-Pickup Notification (MSG91)

- The second staff mark the order **Ready**, the system triggers the MSG91 messaging service.
- An automated WhatsApp message or SMS is sent to the student with their token number and pickup counter name.
- On the student's phone, the order card lights up with a live QR collection pass.

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8. QR-Verified Pickup & Collection

- The student walks to the counter and presents their token number or digital QR pass.
- Counter staff scan the QR code or verify the token number and tap **Mark Collected**.
- The database changes the order status to `collected`, closing the food ticket.
- *(Note: Earlier promotional referral codes and loyalty streak systems have been permanently removed to protect database speed and eliminate any risk of ledger fraud).*

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9. Post-Collection Food Ratings

- Once food is collected, an optional rating prompt appears on the student's screen.
- Students can leave a 1-to-5 star rating and review for the dishes they ate.
- These ratings update dish scores across campus in real time, helping other students find the best meals.

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10. Daily Settlements & Financial Reconciliation

- The platform calculates earnings automatically:
- **Shop Payout**: The canteen owner receives 100% of their official menu prices.
- **Platform Commission**: The 5% system fee is recorded separately for campus maintenance.
- At the end of each day, administrators and shop owners can review their clean sales breakdown and export financial summaries.
